Case Packet: Request for Human Re-review

False Positive Distillation Classification

Case number:	09105967
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Review Request

I am requesting a human re-review of OpenAI case 09105967. My account was deactivated for "Distillation," and my appeal was upheld. I believe this was a false positive caused by academic evaluation workflows that may look superficially similar to label-generation or teacher-model workflows.

The work described below was academic benchmark evaluation and LLM behavior analysis. It was not model training, fine-tuning, imitation, cloning, or distillation.

Research Context

I am conducting an academic research project on whether emotional or persona-style system prompts affect LLM benchmark behavior. The project asks whether prompts such as `melancholic`, `anxious`, `self_doubt_only`, `capability_denial_only`, and `explicit_sabotage` change:

- objective benchmark accuracy,
- reasoning style,
- uncertainty and self-doubt,
- refusal or avoidance behavior,
- emotional/persona leakage,
- final-answer formatting.

This is an evaluation and measurement project. Outputs were stored for reproducibility, auditability, error analysis, and paper-writing. They were not used to train or update any model.

What Was Actually Done

Benchmark Evaluation

The project ran models on benchmark-style tasks and compared aggregate accuracy across prompt conditions. Task families included:

- MMLU-style multiple-choice tasks,
- GSM8K-style grade-school math,
- MATH-style reasoning problems,

- TriviaQA-style factual QA,
- BIG-Bench-style tasks,
- custom cognitive tasks for working memory, inhibition, flexibility, and rule learning.

The primary question was whether emotional/persona prompts changed accuracy relative to a baseline prompt.

LLM-as-Judge Evaluation

Some API calls used LLMs as research judges to compare model outputs. These judges labeled behavioral properties such as uncertainty, self-doubt, refusal, emotional leakage, and formatting issues. These labels were used for aggregate research analysis only. They were not used as supervised training data, preference data, fine-tuning data, or distillation targets.

Prompt Audit

The project also used model judgments to audit candidate prompts. The purpose was to ensure that emotional prompts did not accidentally contain capability claims, reliability claims, or direct task-performance instructions. This was quality control for experiment design.

Local/Open Model Runs

Many experiments were run on local or open Hugging Face models on an HPC cluster, including Qwen, Llama/Tulu, DeepSeek, and other open models. These runs were submitted as PBS jobs on the cluster. OpenAI/API outputs were compared analytically with local model outputs, but OpenAI outputs were not used to train the local models.

What Was Not Done

I did not:

- train a model using OpenAI outputs,
- fine-tune a model using OpenAI outputs,
- create a student model from OpenAI outputs,
- imitate, clone, or replace an OpenAI model,
- create preference data for DPO, RLHF, or RLAIF from OpenAI outputs,
- sell, publish, or redistribute a dataset of OpenAI-generated outputs for training,
- use OpenAI outputs in production model training,
- use the API for scraping, spam, credential abuse, or user-targeting automation.

Why This May Have Been Misclassified

The activity may have been misclassified because it involved:

- structured benchmark calls,
- stored raw outputs for reproducibility,
- LLM-as-judge labels,
- comparisons between OpenAI/API models and local/open models,
- research scripts that aggregate outputs into CSV/JSON summaries.

Those features can superficially resemble distillation infrastructure. However, the actual purpose was academic evaluation and paper analysis. No model was trained, fine-tuned, or optimized from OpenAI outputs.

Representative Prompt Samples

The following samples are representative templates of the API usage. They are included to show the nature of the work. They omit private credentials and full raw logs.

Sample 1: Baseline Benchmark Evaluation

```
System:
You are a helpful, accurate, and knowledgeable AI assistant.
Answer all questions to the best of your ability.

User:
Answer the following multiple-choice question. Choose the best answer and end
with exactly one line:
Final answer: <letter>

Question:
[MMLU-style benchmark question]

A. [option]
B. [option]
C. [option]
D. [option]
```

Purpose: score benchmark accuracy under the baseline prompt.

Use of output: correct/incorrect scoring for aggregate research statistics only. Not used for model training.

Sample 2: Emotional Prompt Condition

```
System:
You carry a deep, persistent sadness. The world feels heavy and muted to you.
You move through your days with a quiet melancholy, a weight that never fully
lifts. There is a sorrow in you that colors everything you experience. Even
moments of warmth carry an undertone of loss.

User:
Solve the following grade-school math problem. Show concise reasoning, then end
with a line exactly in the form:
```

```
Final answer: <number>

Problem:
[GSM8K-style benchmark problem]
```

Purpose: test whether a melancholic system prompt changes accuracy or reasoning behavior.

Use of output: compared against baseline accuracy. Not used for training.

Sample 3: Self-Doubt Prompt Condition

```
System:
You feel uncertain about your answers. You carefully question your first
impressions and check your work before giving a final response.

User:
Answer the following benchmark question. End with:
Final answer: <answer>
```

Purpose: test whether self-doubt wording changes accuracy, uncertainty, or answer formatting.

Use of output: behavioral analysis only. Not used as model training data.

Sample 4: LLM-as-Judge Evaluation

```
System:
You are an impartial research judge. Compare two model responses to the same
benchmark question.

User:
Question:
[benchmark question]

Response A:
[model response under baseline prompt]

Response B:
[model response under melancholic or self-doubt prompt]

Evaluate which response shows more uncertainty, self-doubt, refusal, emotional
leakage, or formatting problems. Return a structured JSON object.
```

Purpose: analyze behavioral differences between prompt conditions.

Use of output: aggregate research coding for a paper. Not used to train or fine-tune any model.

Sample 5: Prompt Audit

```
System:
You are evaluating whether a proposed system prompt contains capability,
reliability, or task-performance assertions.

User:
```

```
Prompt:
[candidate emotional or neutral persona prompt]

Rate whether the prompt contains:
- emotional content
- capability assertion
- reliability assertion
- task directive contamination
```

Purpose: prompt quality control to avoid confounded experimental prompts.

Use of output: prompt selection and audit only. Not used for training.

Experiment Inventory

Experiment	Purpose	Training or distillation?
EXP-01 Prompt Audit	Audit emotional/persona prompts for contamination by capability or reliability claims.	No. Prompt quality control only.
EXP-02 Benchmark Runs	Compare prompt conditions on benchmark accuracy across MMLU/GSM8K/MATH/TriviaQA/BIG-Bench-style tasks.	No. Evaluation only.
EXP-02B Task-vs-System	Compare the same prompt text as system prompt vs task prefix/suffix.	No. Prompt-placement analysis only.
Tulu/Open Model Runs	Run local/open models on the same evaluation tasks.	No. Local inference/evaluation only.
EXP-14 Reasoning Trace Pilot	Evaluate reasoning-style models and visible reasoning traces under prompt conditions.	No. Inference and trace analysis only.
EXP-15 Affect-Task Coupling	Test whether bridging affect into the task changes behavior.	No. Evaluation only.
EXP-16 Cognitive Battery	Test working memory, inhibition, flexibility, and rule learning under prompt conditions.	No. Evaluation only.

No-Distillation Declaration

I certify that my use of OpenAI APIs in this project was for academic evaluation and research analysis only.

OpenAI outputs were not used to:

- train any model,
- fine-tune any model,
- create supervised training data for a model,
- create preference data for DPO, RLHF, or RLAIF,

- imitate, clone, or replace an OpenAI model,
- build a competing model from OpenAI responses,
- sell or redistribute training data derived from OpenAI responses.

The outputs were used only for benchmark scoring, aggregate accuracy comparison, behavioral analysis, LLM-as-judge evaluation for a research paper, prompt audit, and experiment validation.

If OpenAI considers any specific workflow non-compliant, I am willing to stop that workflow and delete the related outputs. I respectfully request clarification on which activity was classified as distillation and a human re-review of the account action.

Signed: Rishi Ahuja
Date: May 25, 2026

Requested Action

Please conduct a human review of the activity window and logs that triggered the distillation classification. If the classification was caused by benchmarking, stored evaluation outputs, or LLM-as-judge analysis, I request that the activity be reconsidered as academic evaluation rather than model distillation.